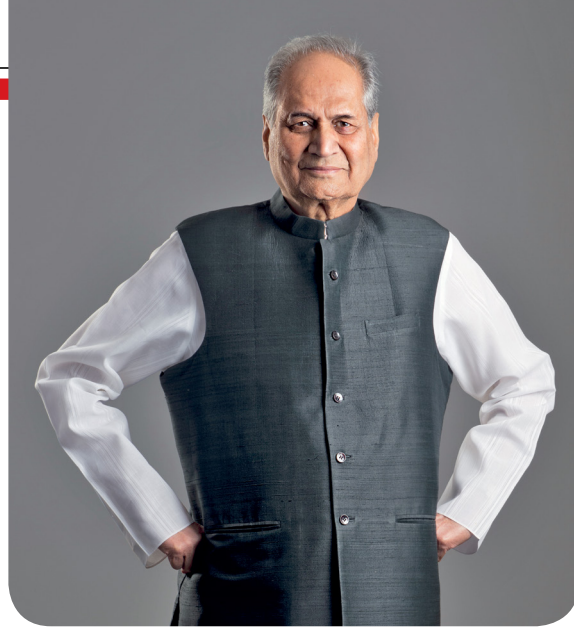


RACHIT GOSWAMI

Rahul Bajaj *(1938-2022)*

Former Chairman Emeritus, Bajaj Group

Rahul Bajaj was one of those few industrialists who had seen business thrive in an era of the so-called 'Licence Raj' with almost no competition from overseas players, as well as in an open economy post-1991. He started his journey with the Bajaj Group in 1965 at the age of 30, and became managing director in 1972 after the demise of his father, Kamalnayan Bajaj. The group was set up by his grandfather Jamnalal Bajaj, a close associate of Mahatma Gandhi, in 1926. Bajaj was known for his candour, and when he spoke up, policymakers took note. He championed local manufacturing and argued for a level playing field for the Indian industry in the post-liberalisation era. Under him, the Bajaj Group saw big diversifications into insurance, financial services and electrical products. Rahul Bajaj will perhaps be most remembered for the iconic Bajaj Chetak that was a runaway success for several years.

Adi Godrej, *80*

Former Chairman, Godrej Group

Adi Godrej, who started his leadership role in the group as a managing director of Godrej Soaps in 1963 at the age of 21, had himself become synonymous with the group. Founder Ardeshir Godrej failed in a few ventures before striking success with the locks business. Next came security equipment and steel furniture. From soaps, it moved to detergents and personal/ household products. Since vegetable oil was used to make soap, the byproduct, oil cake, was marketed as animal feed. With a large landholding in Vikhroli near Mumbai, the group also forayed into real estate. The Godrej Group enjoys the patronage of 1.1 billion consumers globally. Adi Godrej stepped down as Godrej group chairman in August 2021.



BANDEEP SINGH



GETTY IMAGES

N.R. Narayana Murthy, *76*

Co-founder & Former Chairman, Infosys

The son of a small-town school teacher from Karnataka, Murthy is globally recognised as a doyen of India's phenomenally successful IT industry. He ignited entrepreneurial dreams in millions by demonstrating that intellectual capital can help a middle-class Indian create a billion-dollar enterprise. Murthy conceived and implemented the business model responsible for the growth of Infosys and Indian IT at large. Infosys was the first Indian IT company to list on a US stock exchange, and is a leader in setting corporate governance benchmarks. While it created wealth, it was a pioneer in distributing it too, through employee stock options that have made over 30,000 of its employees millionaires.